documentary film starring Stanislav Petrov and Kevin Costner).[9] How high was the risk of Soviet nuclear retaliation? More senior officers in the chain of command were aware of malfunctioning early warning technology and also realised it would be unlikely for a US ICBM strike to be limited to five missiles (even if its purpose was decapitation of the Soviet state). Those higher in the chain of command would most likely have reached the same conclusion as Colonel Petrov. But they might not.

Yet another man who saved the world

The case of Stanislav Petrov is, nevertheless, a reminder that subordinate actors can be restraining and stabilising factors. One of the most dramatic examples of this, and indeed one of the most dramatic accounts of how close we may have been to nuclear war in 1962, is provided by Aaron Tovish for *The Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists* in 2015.[10] Martin Sherwin also examines the episode in *Gambling with Armageddon.* [11] The primary source for the account is a member of a launch crew in the 873rd Tactical Missile Squadron based on Okinawa, John Bordne. The squadron was equipped with thirty-two long-range Mace cruise missiles (each armed with a 1.1 megaton-yield warhead). These were aimed at targets in China and the Soviet Union (with a range that could reach Beijing). Bordne's account was contested by other crew members, and documentary evidence (that may well exist) has not yet been declassified.

According to Bordne, in the early hours of 28 October (local time) the squadron received authenticated orders to launch its missiles. USAF Captain William Bassett was the senior duty officer who decided that because of procedural irregularity, clarification of the order was necessary. He was soon convinced the order was in error. When one of the junior launch officers announced his intention to fire his missiles, Bassett had airmen sent to restrain, and, if necessary, shoot him. The order to fire the nuclear missiles was subsequently withdrawn (and a senior officer held responsible for what happened apparently court-martialled). If Bordne's account is accurate then not only was there an extremely serious risk that nuclear weapons might be fired, but that they could also strike Soviet (and